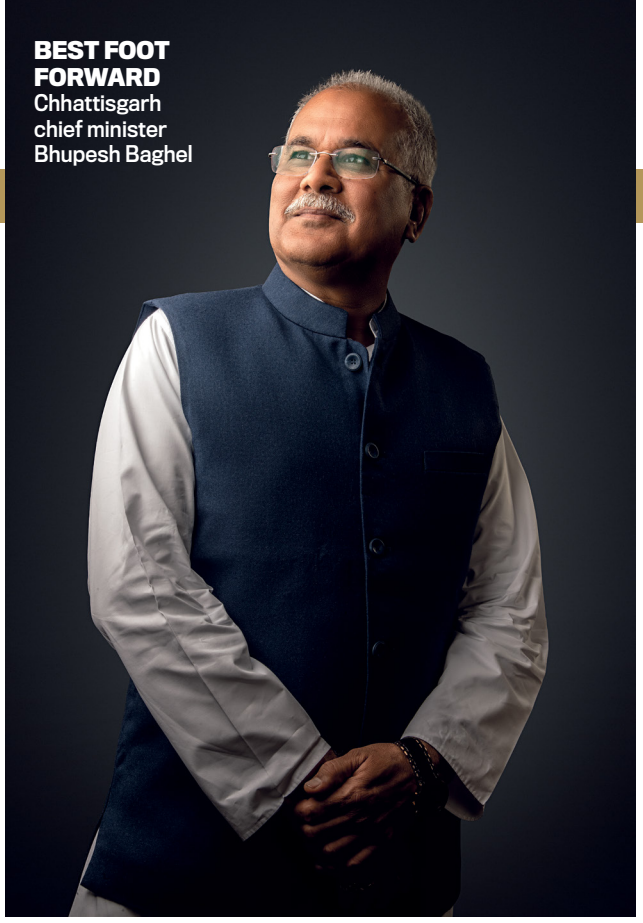
CATEGORY WINNERS **ENVIRONMENT**

GREEN IS THE WAY TO GO

Despite challenges, Chhattisgarh makes strides in terms of environmental action, while Sikkim focuses on grassroots participation



BEST FOOT FORWARD Chhattisgarh chief minister Bhupesh Baghel

BANDEEP SINGH

Four states, in particular, have set a fine example in terms of environmental action. While the rankings are based on various parameters such as SO_2, NO_2 and particulate matter (PM) concentration and forest cover, the four states have taken steps that address issues beyond these factors.

Best Performing Big State: Kerala

Even though Kerala constitutes only 1.2 per cent of India, its forest cover is 2.3 per cent of the national average. Blessed with the Western Ghats, 44 rivers and a long coastal belt, it's one of the most sensitive bio-hotspots in the country. The recorded forest area is about 29.65 per cent of the geographical area (38,863 sq. km).

Currently, the state's biggest challenge in dealing with climate change is carbon emissions and introducing scientific methods for greenhouse technology. Within the energy sector, transport (54%) was the highest contributor to greenhouse gas emissions, followed by buildings (21%). Also, places like the Munroe Island in Kollam are at risk with the rise in sea level.

The Vulnerability Atlas of India identifies 15.7 per cent of Kerala as flood-prone. "We are conscious about the challenges posed by climate change… Our priority is to provide clean water, air and earth for Kerala," says CM Pinarayi Vijayan.

Best Performing Small State: Mizoram

Earlier this year, the Mizoram government, following protests by activists, issued a stay order against the National Highway Infrastructure Development Corporation Limited for its work at some construction sites. The activists alleged that the PSU had violated environmental norms during its work on several national highways in the state.

Such a proactive response by the government is not common in India. But that's what sets Mizoram apart. In 2020, the SO_2 concentration (residential and industrial) was estimated to be 2 μ/m3 and NO_2 concentration (residential and industrial) 6 μ/m3, both the lowest among all small states. At 85 per cent, Mizoram has the highest forest cover among all states. The air quality index (AQI) has been the best—even during the winter, when India's average AQI is graded 'poor', at best. In November, when New Delhi and many other cities were grappling with severe pollution, Chief Minister Zoramthanga invited people to visit Mizoram and "breathe clean air".

MIZORAM, THE BEST PERFORMING SMALL STATE, HAS DONE WELL ON MOST PARAMETERS

Most Improved Big State: Chhattisgarh

In Chhattisgarh, coal, iron ore and dolomite production has led to the proliferation of mineral-based industries, leading to a rise in pollution. But the government has responded to these challenges positively.